

Mental health challenges amongst international graduate students in United States

Context

50% international graduate students enrolled in the US universities faces mental health challenges

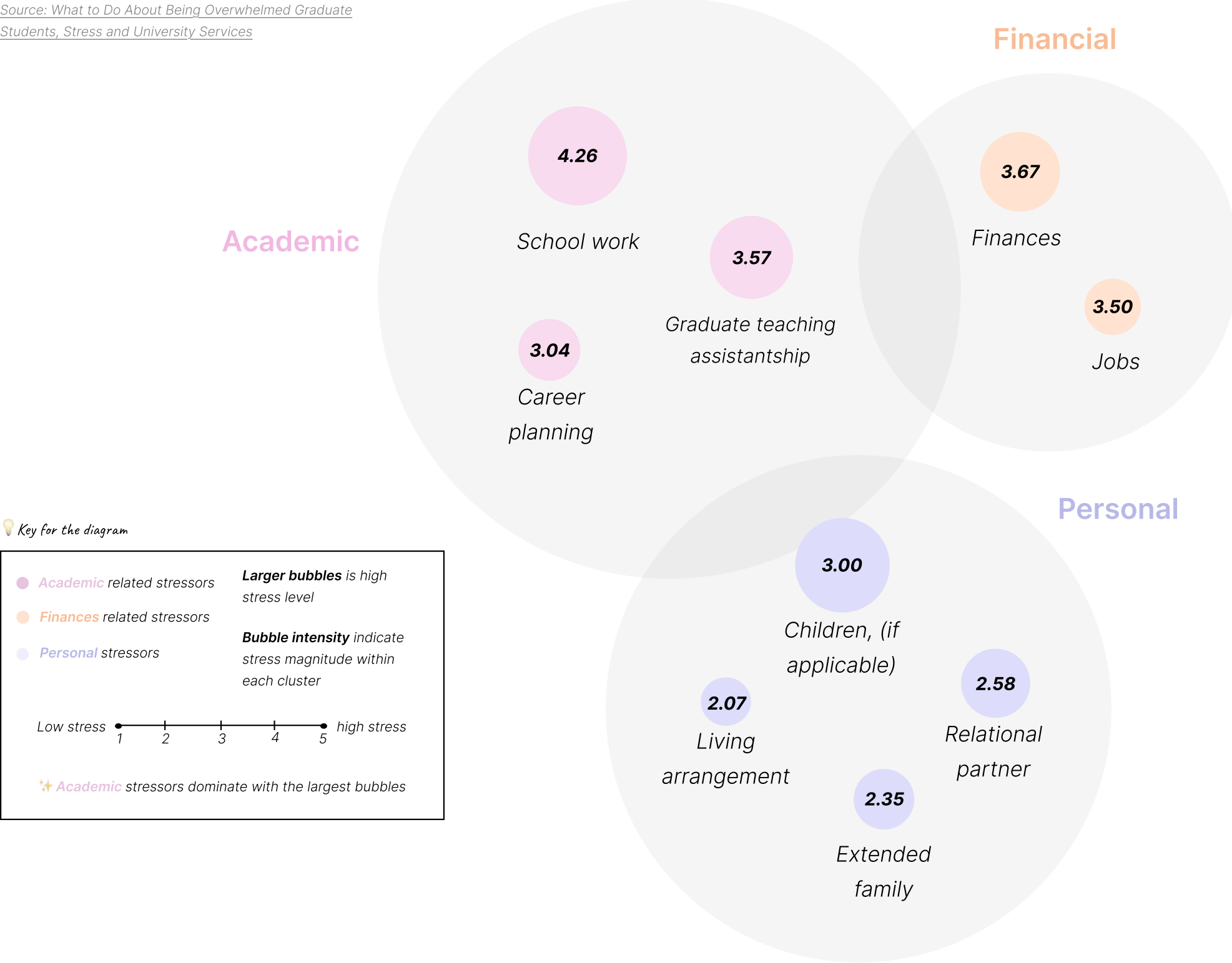
According to the Purdue University A survey of over 220,000 students across 233 universities found that about half of international students screened positive for depression, anxiety, eating disorders, self-injury, or suicidal thoughts.

International students come from many different countries, backgrounds, and languages. But no matter their differences, many of them face big challenges in U.S. universities, such as language difficulties, cultural differences, legal issues, and discrimination.

Source: Purdue University, Mental health of international students studying in the U.S.
Source: HHS students triumph over cultural differences, social hurdles and language barriers

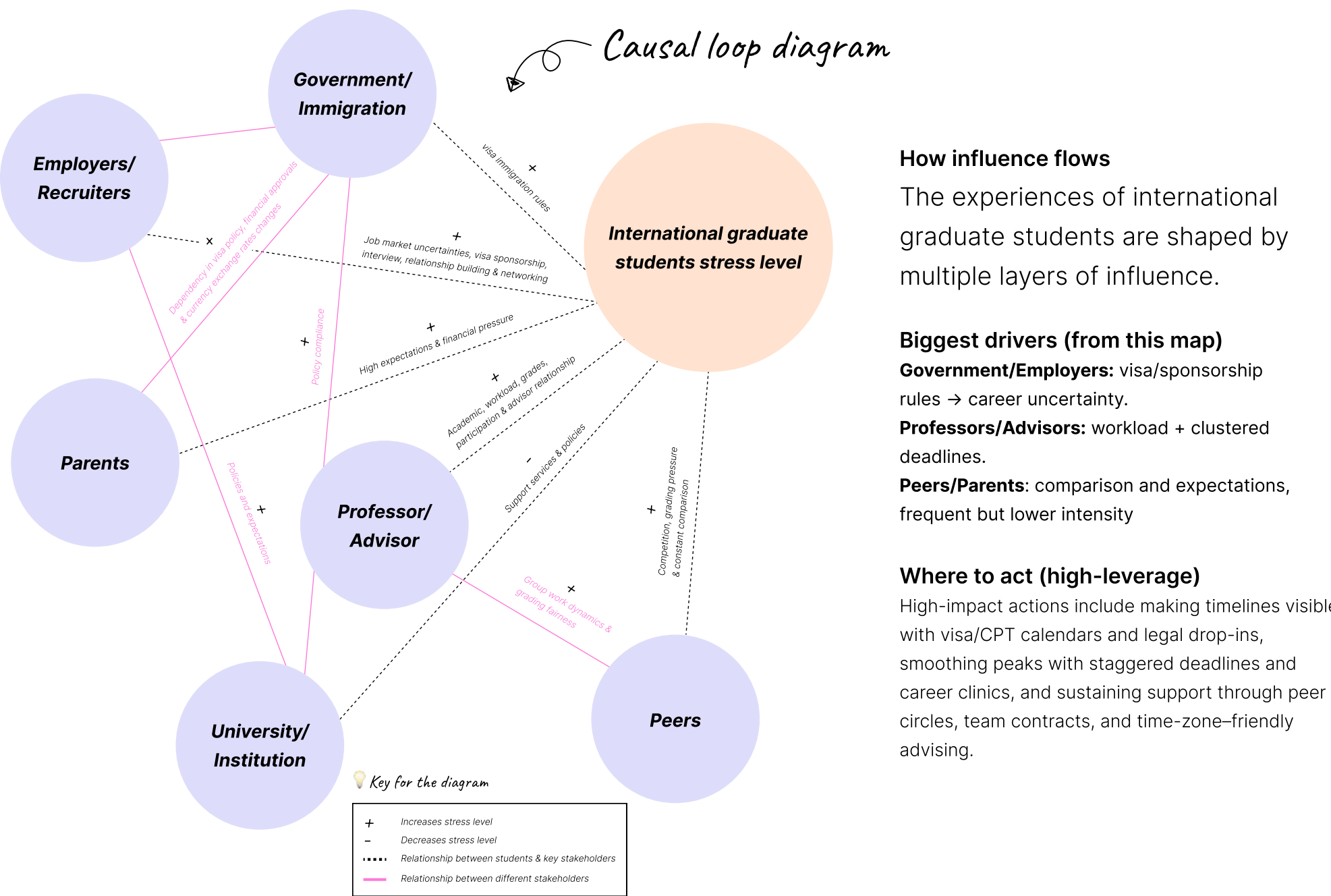
Internal factors influencing stress level

This graph illustrates internal factors that influence stress levels among graduate students, grouped into three main categories: Academic, Financial, and Personal.

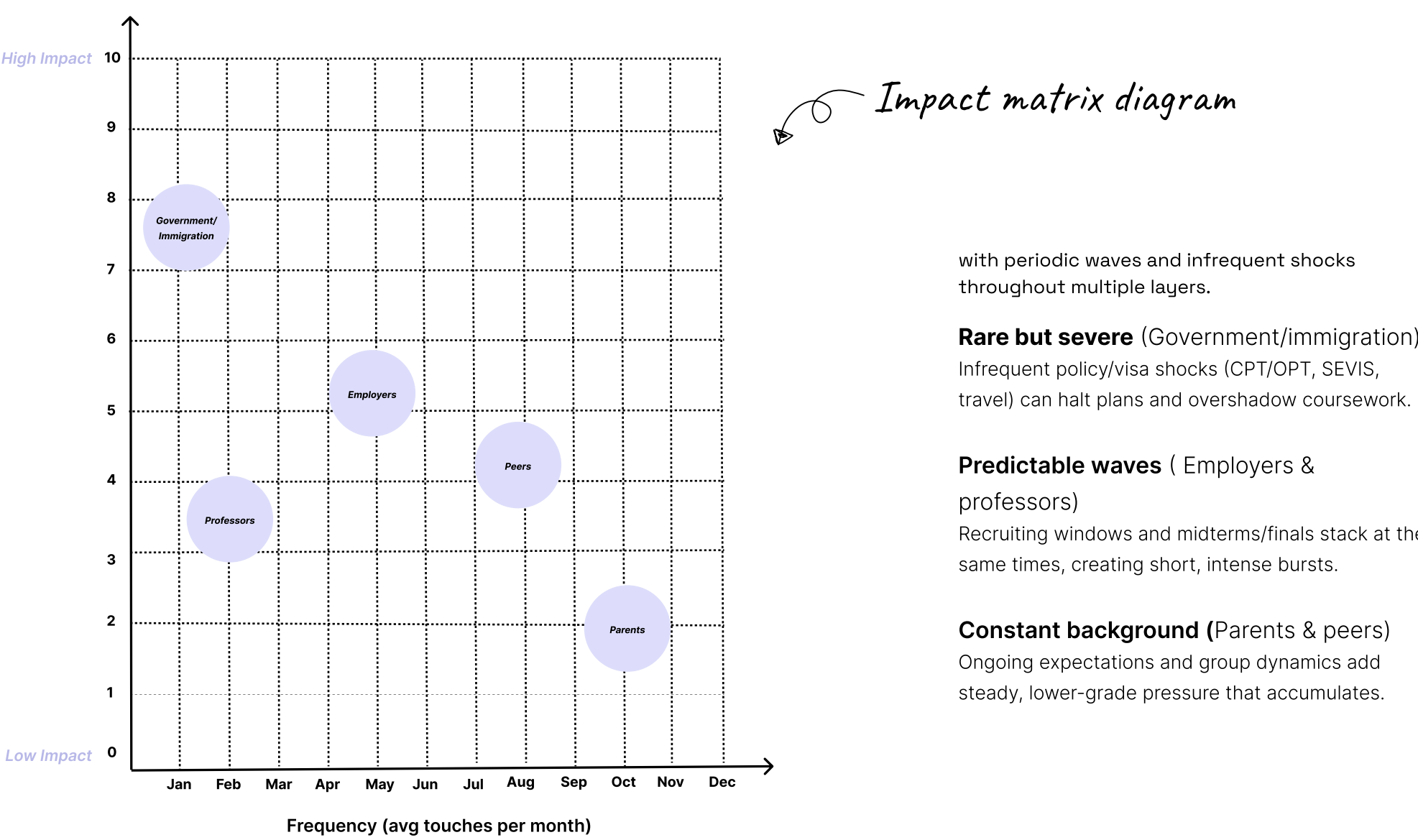


Systems Mapping

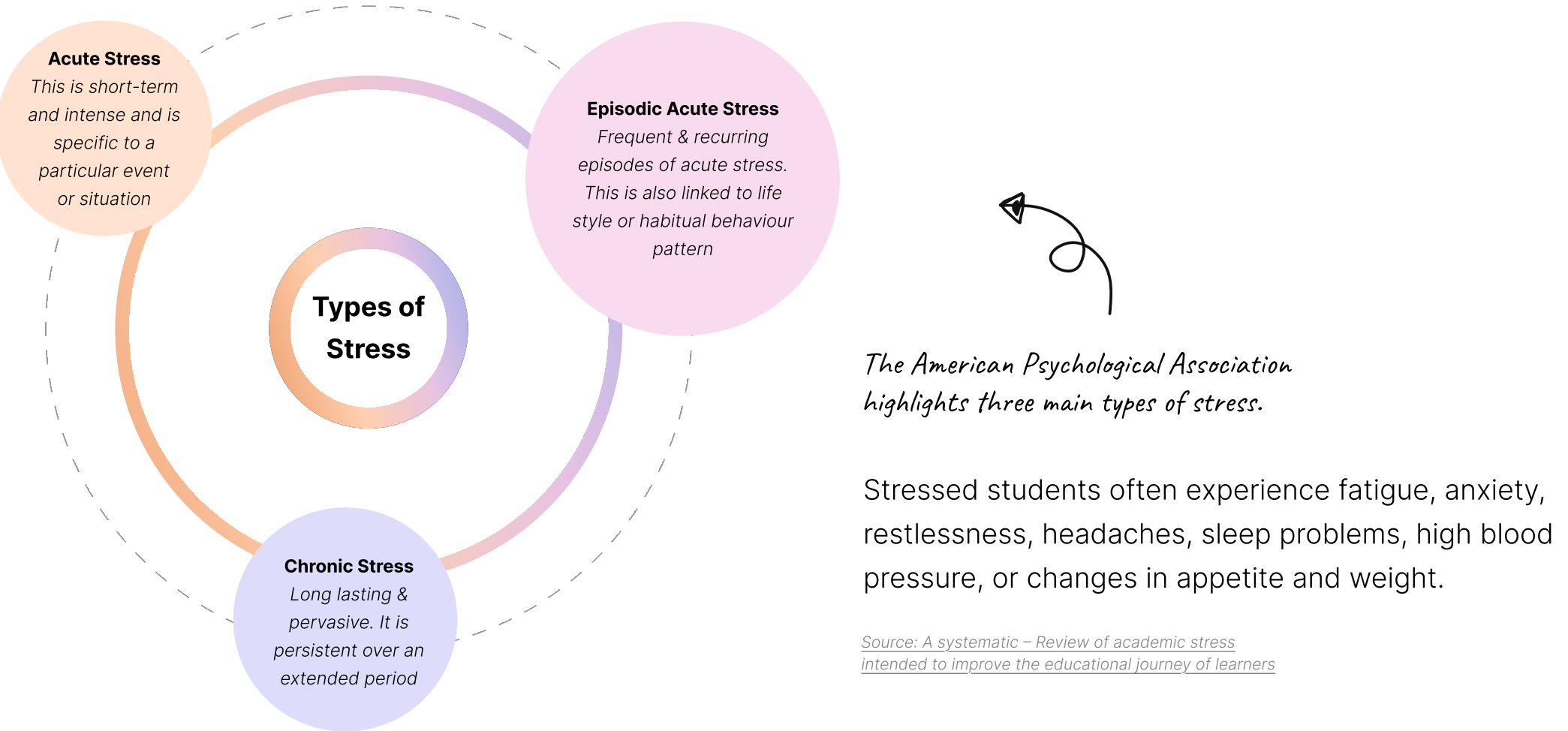
How key stakeholders raise or reduce stress across policies, academic waves, and daily pressures.



International graduate students experience baseline pressure



Every student handles challenges differently



External factors: Recent US government laws & regulations on H-1B visas.

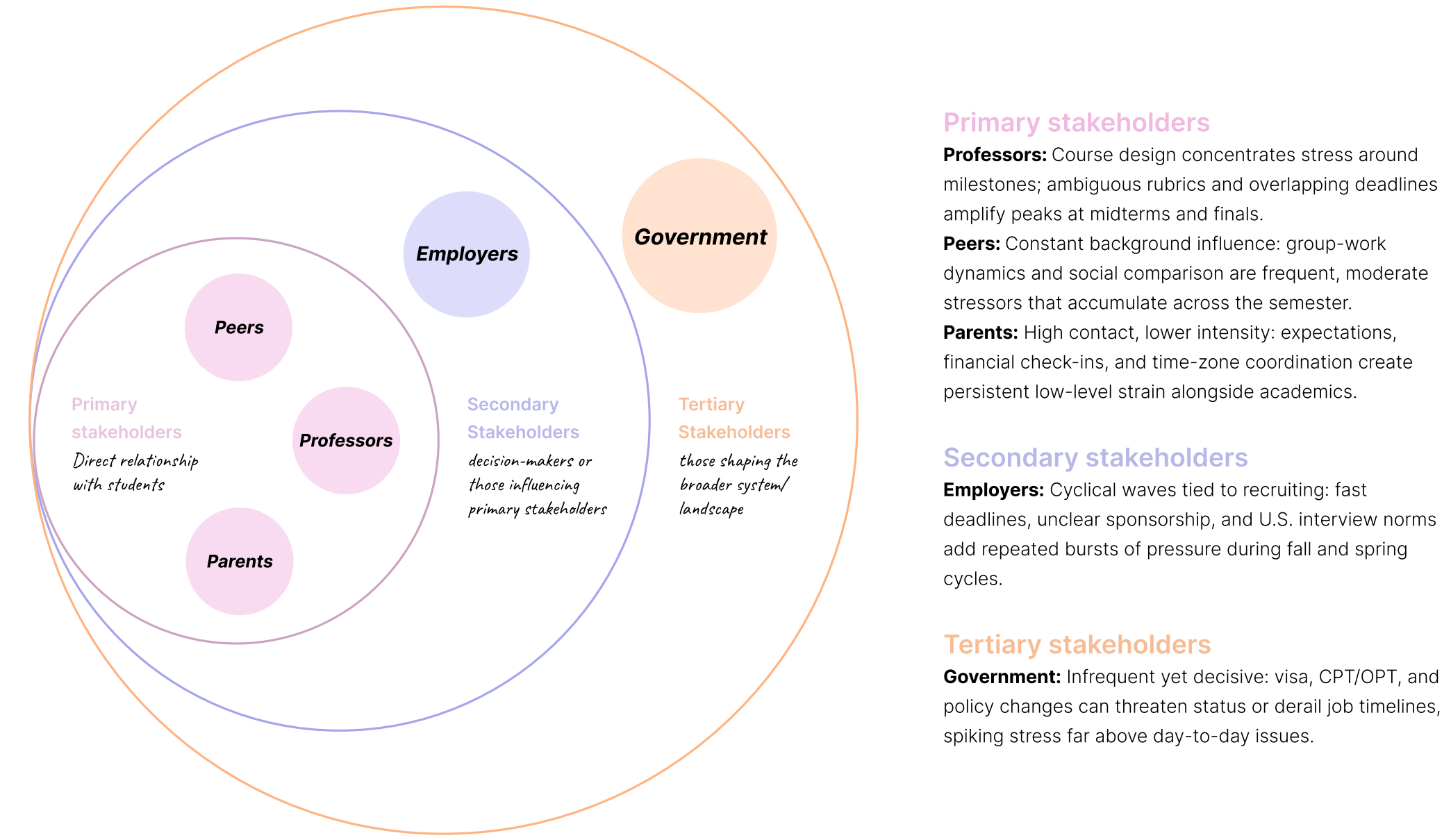
USCIS has introduced several updates impacting H-1B processes for international students.

Registration is now beneficiary-centric, with integrity checks and added start-date flexibility. The registration fee will rise sharply from \$10 to \$215 starting with the March 2025 cap (FY 2026). Premium processing fees also increased, with the new I-907 amount effective February 26, 2024. Additionally, DHS issued a final modernization rule effective January 17, 2025, alongside a revised Form I-129, with further proposed changes ahead. A weighted selection favoring higher-wage roles has also been proposed but is not yet finalized.

Source: Whitehouse.gov
Source: U.S Department of States

Stakeholder Mapping

Stakeholders who influence student's stress level



Interventions

Niche, Regime & Landscape diagram maps where international grad student's stress comes from and where to intervene.

	Economic	Socio - Cultural	Political
Landscape	Inflation and volatile job market. Action: Transparent updates on costs and aid.	Stigma and cultural adjustment. Action: Normalize help during welcome week.	Visa/CPT/OPT uncertainty. Action: Frequent job conferences held on campus.
Regime	Complex employment paths. Action: GA/RA pipelines, micro-grants, and paid roles	Isolation in small cohorts. Action: Cross-cultural peer mentoring and student groups.	Complicated policy processes. Action: Legal advising and CPT/OPT workshops.
Niche	Budget stress & tax confusion. Action: Budget templates and F-1 tax basics sessions.	Difficulty assimilating to culture. Action: Doing extracurricular activities to build community	Job search near graduation. Action: One-page checklists and pre-deadline drop-ins.

This diagram maps where international grad student stress comes from and where to intervene.

It shows impact across students, structures and systems at Niche, regime and landscape level. This intensifies with recruiting/academic peaks and everyday pressures (money admin, paperwork, belonging) to raise overall load.

The takeaway: make timelines visible (visa/CPT), simplify aid-and-work routes while strengthening peer support, and give lightweight tools for budgeting and paperwork so peaks are smoothed.

Consequences

Making timelines more visible, smoothing academic and recruiting peaks, and adding light financial and paperwork supports can lower peak stress, ease daily burdens, and free up time and attention for learning and career steps. The expected outcomes include fewer crises around visa/CPT deadlines and finals, higher rates of on-time submissions and interview/offer success, greater use of advising, tele-mental health, and cohort circles, as well as reduced late fees, clearer budgets, and better tax compliance. Together, these targeted system fixes and simple student tools can reduce stress spikes, create a steadier baseline, and lead to stronger academic, career, and well-being outcomes.